Lean Coffee

A structured, agenda-less meeting: the group sets the topics, votes on them, and talks about what matters most.

Facilitation Toolkit · Participant-Driven Meetings · Timeboxed Conversations

WORKED EXAMPLE · FICTIONAL TEAM

LEGEND

- Yellow Sticky = Discussion Topic
- Green Sticky = Takeaway / Action
- Dot = Vote (3 per person)

1 To Discuss

What do we want to talk about?

- One topic per sticky, pitched in a sentence
- Dot-vote, then sort by votes (most at the top)

Too many meetings on Thursdays ●●●

How's pairing with Ravi going? ●●

Better test data ●●

Celebrate the reorder launch? ●

Is our WIP limit too low? ●

2 Discussing — NOW

What are we discussing now?

CURRENT TOPIC

Should we stop estimating in points? ●●●●●

TIMEBOX (TICK EACH ROUND)

☑ 8 min ☑ + 4 min ☐ + 2 min

WHEN THE TIMER ENDS, VOTE

↑ Keep going → Wrap up ↓ Move on

Majority ↑ extends the timer · otherwise pull the next topic

Key takeaway:

Try counting items for two iterations;
keep points for rough sizing of big work.
Tom checks the forecast still works.

3 Discussed

What have we covered?

- Move the topic here when the group moves on
- Add a green sticky with the key takeaway

The retro format feels stale

Try a Sailboat retro next time

On-call handover gets missed

Hand over in the Monday sync

1 Brainstorm topics — 5 min · one topic per sticky

2 Pitch & dot-vote — One sentence each · 3 dots per person

3 Discuss the top topic — Start the 8-minute timer

4 Keep going or move on? — Vote ↑ → ↓ when time is up

5 Capture takeaways — Green sticky, then move to Discussed

TAKEAWAYS & ACTIONS

Action #1 Count items, not points, for 2 iterations

Owner: Tom

Done when: forecast compared at the retro

Action #2 Move Thursday refinement to Tuesday

Owner: Priya

Done when: the calendar is updated

Action #3 Copy anonymised orders for test data

Owner: Alex

Done when: test data is on staging

"What's the most valuable thing we could talk about right now?"

"Has this conversation run its course, or is there more value to unlock?"

© 2026 Eric Parker · CC BY 4.0 · eparker71.github.io/better-delivery-toolkit